

Subjects

The Outline of Cultural Materials

The Outline of Cultural Materials (OCM) is a vast subject index designed to cover all aspects of cultural and social life. It was first developed in the 1930s by George Peter Murdock and colleagues at Yale's Institute of Human Relations and has been revised ever since. In the eHRAF databases, these subjects have been used to index each and every paragraph in the over 700,000+ pages of ethnographic and archaeological documents, including books, journal articles and dissertations. This means that we have tagged each paragraph with intricate metadata about its contents---whether it discusses a specific type of "musical instrument" (OCM # 504), or whether it depicts content about the "the aftermath of combat" (OCM # 727). This tagging system means you can search across all of our collections to find the exact paragraph-level content you need, regardless of the language, verbiage, or spelling conventions the author uses.

At the beginning of the HRAF project in the 1940's, users had to know the 3-digit numbers to identify each OCM subject. Today, users don't need to use these codes (although they can still be quite useful for precisely tagging users' research notes and photographs). Instead, user-defined topics are matched against our interactive thesaurus in real time. For example, if you were to type in the very broad term "aggression" as a search topic in Advanced Search, our platform points you to a number of specific OCM terms dealing with aggression---from aggression (international threats) for which we suggest External Relations (OCM 648) to interpersonal aggression for which we suggest Ingroup Antagonisms (578), along with six other specific topics. Using these suggested topics, users can either narrow their research question to a specific aspect of aggression or they can keep their topic extremely broad by searching for all possible topics of aggression. In Advanced Search these OCMs can be combined with each other to either narrow a search or broaden a search with alternative subjects. In addition, searches can combine subjects and keywords in order to further hone their results.

The critical thing to note is that unlike other databases our searches are always executed at the paragraph-level to maximize your ability to retrieve appropriate information.

Uses

- Finding and comparing cultural topics across languages and times
- Conducting cross-cultural research and hypothesis testing
- Cataloging field notes
- Cataloging museum collections
- Cataloging multimedia research collections in a comparative cross-cultural way

Further Info

- Detailed descriptions of [each OCM here](#).
- Find our video user guide, our textual guide, and other support resources [here](#).



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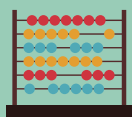
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